Arabs, Tunisians, Somalis as well as British and American jihadis trained alongside him.[157] His training lasted two and a half months, during which time Brigitte alleged military materials were airdropped by army helicopters and collected by the new recruits.[158] Notably, he also asserted that the group was forewarned in advance of swoops designed to ensure foreigners were not present in its camps. Brigitte says he witnessed such inspections on four occasions during his ten weeks in the mountains, each time from the woods skirting the camp, where he was directed to hide by Lashkar members who were forewarned that the inspectors were coming.[159]

Lashkar was training Westerners, including Americans, prior to 9/11. Some of those who went through its camps later facilitated entrance for others who sought to wage jihad against the US. The case of the Virginia Jihad Network, introduced in Chapter 4, exemplifies the role that these pre-existing networks played in promoting Lashkar as a training provider. It is also illustrates the manner in which the group continued to leverage these networks for its own logistical purposes. Three men from the Virginia Jihad Network traveled to Pakistan to train with Lashkar before 9/11: Randall Todd Royer, Ibrahim Ahmed al-Hamdi and Seifullah Chapman. The latter was at one of Lashkar's camps on 9/11. As he was making his way back to America in the days following the attacks, Ali Al-Timimi, a native US citizen and leader at a mosque in Northern Virginia, gathered together others from the Virginia Jihad Network. He encouraged the group to answer Mullah Omar's call to defend Afghanistan against the anticipated US invasion. Four men agreed to do so: Mohammed Aatique; Khwaja Mahmood Hasan; Masoud Ahmad Khan; and Yong Ki Kwon. Al-Timimi and Royer advised them that Lashkar would be the best group with which to train in preparation for fighting against American forces in Afghanistan. Royer also phoned his Lashkar contacts to smooth the way and provided contact information to the four men, all of whom made the trip to Lashkar's Masada camp near Muzaffarabad in Pakistan-administered Kashmir.[160] A month after the initial meeting in Northern Virginia, Ali Asad Chandia also traveled to Pakistan at al-Timimi's urging and presented himself at the Lashkar office in Lahore.[161]

The US invasion of Afghanistan made American forces legitimate targets in their eyes, just as were Russian soldiers in Chechnya or Indian